

May 8, 2025

Foundation of the Louisville Free Public Library

Chandra Gordan, Executive Director

301 York Street, Louisville, Kentucky 40203

Grant Purpose: Purchase 500 New Books

Funding Request: \$10,000

Mary P. Surrey, President

Max and Victoria Dreyfus Foundation

2233 Wisconsin Avenue NW, Suite 414, Washington, D.C. 20007

Dear Ms. Surrey:

The Foundation of the Louisville Free Public Library submits this request for \$10,000 in support of the purchase of 500 new books for the Louisville Free Public Library (LFPL) system. As a nonprofit organization, our mission is to strengthen and expand the library's services, programs, and resources so that every Louisville and Jefferson County resident has free, equitable access to education, information, and enrichment. The funding we seek will directly enhance the library's collection as it will help to provide reading materials to thousands of community members, particularly children, low-income families, and underserved populations who rely on the public library as their primary, and often only, source of books and educational support.

The Foundation of the Louisville Free Public Library was established to support and enhance the work of the Louisville Free Public Library, which serves a diverse urban and suburban community of nearly 800,000 residents. The library's system of 17 branches welcomes more than 3 million visitors annually, offering free resources to patrons of all ages and backgrounds (Giffin, 2024). Our mission is rooted in the belief that libraries are essential to building stronger, more resilient communities by providing free access to knowledge, fostering intellectual curiosity, and promoting literacy.

The Louisville Free Public Library stands apart from many other library systems due to the scale and scope of its services, the diversity of the population it serves, and its commitment to outreach in underserved neighborhoods. LFPL offers a range of programs, including early childhood literacy initiatives like the 1000 Books Before Kindergarten Challenge, which encourages families to read at least 1,000 books with their young children before they enter kindergarten. The library also provides Homework Help centers, offering free online tutoring and access to educational resources. Adult education workshops, such as GED preparation and English language learning programs, further demonstrate LFPL's dedication to lifelong learning. Moreover, LFPL has been recognized for its collaborations with Jefferson County Public Schools and organizations like Metro United Way, exemplified by initiatives such as the Share 100 Stories Before 4th Grade program ("Louisville," 2016). These comprehensive services are supported by a robust and continually updated collection of books and reading materials, ensuring that the library remains a vital resource for the community.

In the first summary, it reads, "The Louisville Free Public Library Foundation supports the Louisville Free Public Library system in providing free and equitable access to information, education, and cultural enrichment for all residents of Louisville and Jefferson County. In addition to supporting technology, programming, and services, the Foundation focuses on ensuring that children, families, and low-income individuals have access to books and learning resources." This statement captures the heart of the Foundation's work as we are not just supporting the library's broader operations; we are directly investing in the tools that foster literacy, learning, and growth. While new technologies and programs are critical, we know that access to books remains the most fundamental building block for education, literacy development, and intellectual empowerment. Without books, many of our other efforts would be significantly weakened. Thus, the Foundation's commitment to continually refreshing and strengthening the library's collection plays an irreplaceable role in ensuring that every individual, regardless of age, background, or income, can access the knowledge they need to succeed.

In the secondary summary, it reads, "Funding from the Max and Victoria Dreyfus Foundation will be used to purchase new books for the library's collection, with a focus on children's, teen, and adult literacy materials. This will benefit the population we serve by expanding access to current, high-quality reading materials, supporting literacy development, encouraging lifelong learning, and ensuring that community members have free access to books and information." This expansion of the original mission-specific work highlights the practical and immediate application of the requested funding. In concrete terms, the \$10,000 requested would allow the library to purchase approximately 500 new books, strategically selected to meet demonstrated community needs. This expansion is not only about numbers but about the impact. When we have more copies of diverse and popular books, it will help towards supporting a child

in learning to read, inspiring a teenager to dream bigger, equipping an adult to build better skills for employment, or simply offering joy and discovery through literature. Each book added to the collection will serve hundreds of individuals over its lifetime, multiplying the reach of the initial investment many times over. In this way, the proposed project represents the Foundation's mission and increases its outcomes to ensure lasting, community-wide benefits from a single act of generosity.

Moreover, receiving this grant will support the broader societal goals by addressing systemic inequalities in access to educational resources. Research shows that access to books is a key predictor of literacy success, academic performance, and even economic mobility. This is detailed in the academic article, "Reading for life-long health," which says, "Children from homes that encourage literacy are more likely to achieve future academic success, as those with more books at home achieve, on average, three years more schooling, regardless of their parents' education, occupation, and economic status... Adults who read for more than 3.5 hours a week were 20 percent less likely to die over the 12-year study follow-up than those who didn't read books. Simply put: 'The benefits of reading books include a longer life in which to read them'" (Shulman, Baicker, & Mayes, 2024). By ensuring that every child, teen, and adult in Louisville has free access to high-quality books, regardless of income or background, the LFPL Foundation helps build a more equitable, educated, and prosperous community for all.

In closing, the Foundation of the Louisville Free Public Library is deeply committed to fostering literacy, education, and opportunity for everyone in Louisville and Jefferson County. By supporting our effort to purchase 500 new books, the Max and Victoria Dreyfus Foundation would be making an immediate and lasting investment in the future of our community. Together, we can ensure that the doors to knowledge, imagination, and opportunity remain open to all for generations to come.

On behalf of the Foundation of the Louisville Free Public Library, its dedicated staff and volunteers, and the thousands of residents we serve, I sincerely thank you for considering our request. We would be honored to partner with the Max and Victoria Dreyfus Foundation in advancing the transformative power of books and libraries in the lives of our community members.

Sincerely,

Alexus Adkins, Student Grant Writer

On behalf of the Foundation of the Louisville Free Public Library

References:

Giffin, C. (2024, December 26). *What is Louisville reading? Data shines light on Kentucky's biggest library*. Courier Journal. <https://www.courier-journal.com/story/news/>

Louisville Free Public Library wins first place in national industry award. (2016, March 28). LouisvilleKY.gov. <https://louisvilleky.gov/news/louisville-free-public-library>

Shulman, K., Baicker, K., & Mayes, L. (2024, July 24). Reading for life-long health. *Frontiers in Pediatrics*, 12. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fped.2024.1401739>